

Introduction

From the early years of the internet, HTML has always been the fundamental format for transmitting information over the web. HTML which stands for HyperText Markup Language was the primary language used to develop webpages over the internet. But initially, HTML started off as a purely structural markup language composed of structural elements to define things like paragraphs, hyperlinks, lists, and headings in text documents.

But as computers and the internet evolved, visual components started getting incorporated into the web and HTML. With this increased interactivity and the appearance of colour displays, aesthetics and design started becoming very important. More and more was required from HTML in terms of presentation. Subsequently HTML had to evolve and incorporate components such as `<font>` and `<big>` to take care of the presentational requirements. But soon even this wasn't enough, even more presentation control was demanded from HTML. As a result tables, frames and other complex markup were incorporated into HTML to help with the presentation of web pages. As the internet grew, web pages became complex and suddenly, the structural language became presentational.

To find a solution to this problem and establish standards across the internet, style sheet languages were proposed by the W3C (World Wide Web Consortium). CSS along with new HTML standards termed XHTML was thus developed to separate the presentation aspect of web design from HTML and restrict it to the structural markup and content only. CSS would take care of the presentational requirements. There were other major advantages of following this approach, which included reduced code, more accessibility and flexibility, lighter web pages and the ability to make site-wide changes across multiple HTML files in an instant.

CSS which stands for Cascading Style Sheets, is the language used to define the presentational aspect of web pages. One of the major advantages of CSS is its simple and easy to understand syntax. Here the code is written to define the presentation and the styling of elements present in a document written with a markup language like HTML or XML. For the rest of this book we will be looking at CSS specifically in conjunction with HTML.

It is important to understand that CSS is designed specifically to separate textual content from its presentation. This crucial division of structure and presentation helps us in getting results faster and creating more compelling